



Confederate cipher reel

This cipher machine captured in Richmond was used by Confederates to encode messages. It used a matrix of 26 alphabets, shifted one letter for each row, from which a substitute letter was chosen for each letter of the message. The cipher was easily cracked by Union code-breakers.

Passing on information

Secret agents and spies took their place among this panoply of intelligence sources. Security was absurdly slack on both sides: officers gave tours of their positions to interested strangers and openly discussed their plans or orders. Thus, well-connected Washington socialite Rose O'Neal Greenhow had easy access to military information that she passed on to Confederate commanders. Her arrest in August 1861 was an early Civil War success for Allan Pinkerton's counterespionage detectives. Another Confederate spy was Belle Boyd of Martinsburg, Virginia; she supplied information to Stonewall Jackson during his Shenandoah Valley Campaign in 1862, before being reported and arrested.

For the Union, Elizabeth Van Lew ran a successful spy network in the Confederate capital, Richmond. One of her most useful contacts was Mary Bowser, a freed slave, who worked as a servant for Jefferson Davis's wife. Both the Union and Confederacy